

Robotaxi Cameras Put Passenger Privacy Under Scrutiny

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Driverless taxis rely on cameras to navigate, but some cameras face the passengers instead of the road. Reporting by WIRED examines how those **interior** recordings are used and why privacy specialists want clearer rules.

Companies say cabin cameras help protect riders and enforce service rules. They can also help workers check cleanliness or locate belongings left behind. Waymo employees have used vehicle **intercoms** to ask passengers whether they were old enough to travel alone, including some adult passengers.

Waymo says **automated** technology helps its teams identify possible violations. A company **patent** describes camera systems performing checks before, during and after rides. However, its spokesperson did not confirm whether that particular **patented** system is being used. A **patent** describes an invention; it does not establish that the invention is operating in a product.

Zoox says its **interior** cameras record the entire ride. Its policies allow personal data to support operations and develop or improve its product. The company also says it might record conversations between passengers and support workers, but does not save those conversation recordings.

Tesla's Robotaxi documents say a green indicator appears on the central touchscreen when the camera is active. Riders can opt into sharing cabin video and audio through the app's privacy settings. The documents also say early access participants automatically opt into data sharing. Tesla did not answer WIRED's questions about whether that program had ended.

Waymo, Zoox and Tesla say human staff view **interior** cameras only when necessary. Their policies also allow personal data, including recordings, to be provided to law enforcement or **regulators**. Waymo says government agencies seeking data are directed to follow valid legal processes.

Justin Brookman of Consumer Reports says vehicles without drivers need ways to check passenger behavior, but also need limits on monitoring. Privacy experts say few clear US rules govern this kind of **surveillance**. Matthew Guariglia of the Electronic Frontier Foundation is concerned about companies collecting information and finding reasons to sell it.

Passengers often agree to lengthy app terms before booking. That leaves an important question: what information does a ride collect, and how much control does the passenger have over its later use?

Word Treasure

interior -- Inside a vehicle or another space.

intercoms -- Systems that let people speak through connected microphones and speakers.

automated -- Working automatically through technology.
patent -- A legal right that protects an invention.
regulators -- Authorities that oversee whether rules are followed.
surveillance -- Monitoring people or activities, such as through cameras.

Background you need

A patent describes a protected invention. Its existence does not establish that a company uses the invention in a product.

The article distinguishes recordings of an entire ride from recordings of conversations with support workers.

Break it down

Introduces WIRED's reporting on cameras facing robotaxi passengers.

Explains company descriptions of safety and service uses.

Examines Waymo's patent and the uncertainty about its use.

Compares Zoox and Tesla recording and sharing practices.

Describes access by staff and government agencies.

Presents named experts' concerns and closes with a question about passenger control.

Why it matters

Cameras can help companies manage driverless rides while collecting passenger information. The article explains why experts want clearer limits on how that information is collected and used.

Test what you remember

1. Which use of cabin cameras do companies describe?
 - (A) Measuring distances to buildings
 - (B) Reading signs beside roads
 - (C) Choosing routes around traffic
 - (D) Checking cleanliness inside vehicles
2. What remained unconfirmed about Waymo's patented camera system?
 - (A) Whether it includes checks during rides
 - (B) Whether it is being used
 - (C) Whether it involves interior cameras
 - (D) Whether it describes an invention
3. What does Zoox say about recordings of conversations with support workers?
 - (A) They are never recorded or shared
 - (B) They may be recorded but are not saved
 - (C) They are always recorded and saved
 - (D) They are saved only between rides
4. What do Tesla's documents say about early access participants?
 - (A) They automatically get extra app settings
 - (B) They automatically see recorded videos
 - (C) They automatically receive shorter rides
 - (D) They automatically opt into data sharing
5. What does Waymo say government agencies seeking data are directed to do?
 - (A) Follow valid legal processes
 - (B) Join the early access program
 - (C) Contact passengers through intercoms
 - (D) Change the app's privacy settings
6. Which position does Justin Brookman express?
 - (A) Cars need longer rides and fewer stops
 - (B) Workers need more recordings and larger screens
 - (C) Cars need behavior checks and monitoring limits
 - (D) Riders need clearer routes and lower fares

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: B 4: D 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **Justin Brookman:** He says vehicles without drivers need ways to check passenger behavior and limits on monitoring.
2. **Matthew Guariglia:** He is concerned about companies collecting more information and finding reasons to sell it.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):